

Truth Seekers: Axis of Distortion

Use this paper to run the end of the game as a group discussion once the room is finished. Part I revisits the data-reading skill behind each puzzle as discussion points. Part II opens up the real history the game is built on. The questions at the end of Part I are a good place to start the conversation.

Part I — What You Just Learned

Every puzzle you solved involved a chart or data visualization in some way. Some you simply had to read carefully. Others had been quietly manipulated, and the trick was spotting how. And a few only gave up their answer once you combined several of them together.

Puzzle 1 • The inverted axis

The line chart looked like incidents were falling and levelling off. They were not. The y-axis was flipped, so the lowest point on the page was actually the highest number.

Lesson: always read the axis before the line. A chart can be perfectly accurate and still mislead through its orientation or scale.

Puzzle 2 • Cross-referencing sources

No single patrol report pointed to an obvious way out. But plotting all four onto the map turned the reports into spatial data, and the gap appeared: the western approaches no one was watching.

Lesson: the truth often lives in the combination of sources. Putting separate records onto a shared frame, like a map, turns scattered text into something you can read at a glance and act on.

Puzzle 3 • Parts of a whole

This one was a hidden-information trick. Folding the sheet a certain way lined up parts of the four donut charts into a new fifth chart with information that led to the solution.

Lesson: information can be deliberately hidden in plain sight, and the way pieces are arranged (or rearranged) can reveal something none of them showed on their own.

Puzzle 4 • The five-number summary

This puzzle had you build a box plot from a set of numbers and read values off it to crack the case combination.

Lesson: a box plot turns a messy list of numbers into five clear reference points, which makes patterns easy to spot once you know how to read it.

Puzzle 5 • Following the flow

The Sankey's start and end totals matched (70 and 70), so it looked honest. But tracing the flow from St. Pölten through to the final node, six prisoners went missing along the way.

Lesson: in a flow diagram, what goes in must come out, so check the path itself and not just the totals at either end.

Puzzle 6 • Triangulating across charts

No single document gave the answer. You had to read three different visualizations: a connections graph, a bar chart, and a deployment map. The skill was holding all three in mind at once and reasoning across them.

Lesson: real questions are often answered not by one source but by the logical connections you draw between several.

Part II — The History Behind the Game

Austria under Nazi rule

In 1938 Nazi Germany annexed Austria in the Anschluss, erasing its independence and folding it into the German Reich. Austrian institutions, culture, and political opposition were suppressed. St. Pölten, between Vienna and Linz, lay in the administrative region the Nazis called Reichsgau Niederdonau.

April 1945: the collapse

By the spring of 1945 the Third Reich was in its final weeks. The Soviet Red Army was advancing from the east while American forces pushed from the west, and air raids struck towns across Austria. St. Pölten had been bombed since the US secured airfields in northern Italy in 1944. The Nazi administration was in chaos. Local offices and security services kept operating with increasing desperation, while many officials destroyed records and tried to flee before the Allies arrived. Arrests and executions intensified in these last days, aimed at deserters, resistance, political enemies, and anyone suspected of “weakening morale.”

Laws used as weapons

The arrests in the game rest on real emergency decrees. Vaguely worded laws, such as the Verordnung gegen Volksschädlinge (§2, crimes committed during air-raid danger) and the Heimtückegesetz (§3(2), on “malicious attacks” on the state and Party), let police and officials decide for themselves who counted as a threat. Looting a damaged home, spreading rumours, or criticising the government could all be treated as serious offences, and in the chaos victims rarely had any chance to defend themselves.

Propaganda on every side

Propaganda was one of the war’s most powerful weapons, used by every major side. Nazi Germany saturated daily life (posters, newspapers, radio, film) carefully chosen messages to encourage loyalty, spread fear of enemies, and prop up morale as defeat became certain. The Allies made use of it too, dropping millions of leaflets over German territory to weaken trust in the leadership. The folded pamphlet in the game is an Allied leaflet of exactly that kind.

The camp and transport system

The concentration-camp system imprisoned people sorted into categories invented by the regime: political prisoners, Jews, Roma and Sinti, clergy, prisoners of war, those labelled “asocial,” and many others. In the final months the system fell into chaos as the Allies closed in. Prisoners were moved repeatedly by train and barge, or forced on long evacuations later known as “death marches,” driven westward while evidence was destroyed. These transports became some of the deadliest

episodes of the war's last weeks, which is exactly what the Sankey diagram, with its six "detached" prisoners, was built to hide.

Resistance

Opposition to Nazi rule was never a single movement. Some people simply tried to survive or quietly helped the persecuted with food, shelter, or false papers; others acted openly — students distributing leaflets, church members objecting, underground political networks, and eventually some military officers. Alongside well-known figures such as Claus von Stauffenberg and the Scholl siblings, St. Pölten had its own resisters in the Widerstandsgruppe Kirchl-Trauttmansdorff. Resistance of any kind remained extremely dangerous: even suspicion could mean arrest or execution.

Mauthausen

Mauthausen, in Upper Austria, was infamous for imprisoning political opponents, resistance members, and prisoners from across occupied Europe. By spring 1945 overcrowding, starvation, and disease had created a humanitarian catastrophe, and record-keeping had broken down. American forces liberated the camp on 5 May 1945, finding thousands of survivors alongside evidence of mass death. But liberation did not bring answers: many prisoners had been transferred, had died in transport, or had vanished from incomplete records. For families searching afterwards, that uncertainty itself became part of the loss — the same uncertainty the soldier voices at the end of the game.

Remembering

Today the site is preserved as a memorial and museum, where survivor testimony, exhibitions, and education keep the victims' identities from being forgotten. Each year a liberation-commemoration ceremony at Mauthausen (one of the largest of its kind in Austria) brings together survivors, descendants, international delegations, school groups, and anti-fascist organizations. The unanswered ending of this game is, in the end, a small reminder of why that remembering matters.